

Researcher Application Guidance

**Office for National Statistics (ONS) and the Department
for Education (DfE)**

Access via the Secure Research Service (SRS)

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Introduction

Summary

This document provides additional guidance from the Office for National Statistics (ONS) and the Department for Education (DfE) on applying to use the Longitudinal Education Outcomes (LEO) dataset in the ONS' Secure Research Service (SRS). This document aims to help researchers understand what is required on a LEO project application to increase efficiency in accessing the data in the SRS.

Who is this publication for?

This publication is for any researcher who is interested in or actively applying to access data in LEO via the SRS.

Section 1: Applying for a LEO Project

Project Accreditation Service for SRS (PASS)

Project applications to access LEO in the SRS are made through the ONS system Project Accreditation Service for SRS (PASS), further information about how to [apply for an accredited research project](#) can be found in Section 3 of this document and on our website.

A downloadable version of the application questions is available in on [PASS](#) although all applications to access data in the Secure Research Service (SRS) must be submitted through [PASS](#).

It is the responsibility of the researcher submitting the application to ensure that all communications regarding the application are responded to in a timely manner so as not to delay the approval process. Please ensure the email address is correct in the application and that inboxes are checked regularly. Regular progress updates will be sent to the researcher who has submitted the application, but if any specific queries arise please contact our team at srs.customer.support@ons.gov.uk.

Project Application Timelines

On average, it can take around 12 weeks for an application to be approved but this is often quicker if the application provides sufficient detail and application guidance is followed correctly. Depending on several factors, for example, the complexity of the

project or the data being requested from and alongside LEO, the process may take longer.

It is important to consider carefully the data that is requested in the application, if any elements are omitted and need requesting at a later part of the application process, this can cause delays. Please consult the [Variable Request Form](#) ahead of submitting your application to determine which variables you will require. Further information on applications can be found in Section 3 of this document and in the 'related documents' section of our website.

Additional Support and Guidance

LEO FAQ Document

A [LEO FAQ document](#) has been published to answer common queries from researchers about the LEO dataset. It is stored in the LEO entry of the [ONS Metadata Catalogue](#), in 'Documentation'.

Research Community

Researchers may wish to join the [LEO Research Community](#) to network with other LEO users to discuss the dataset, ask queries and access useful information.

Research using LEO data

To find out more information on current and expired projects, the UKSA has a [register of accredited projects](#), of which LEO projects can be input in the search bar.

Section 2: Information on the LEO Data

What is LEO?

The Longitudinal Education Outcomes (LEO) standard extract is a relational database from the Department for Education (DfE), which contains information on the labour market outcomes (i.e. employment, earnings, benefits, employer information etc.) and related information (geography) of individuals from schools, colleges and universities. The database comprises of a range of tables where researcher access is restricted on a needs basis.

Where does the Data come from?

LEO brings together data from DfE's LEO partners; the Department for Work and Pensions (DWP) and His Majesty's Revenue and Customs (HMRC) and is now

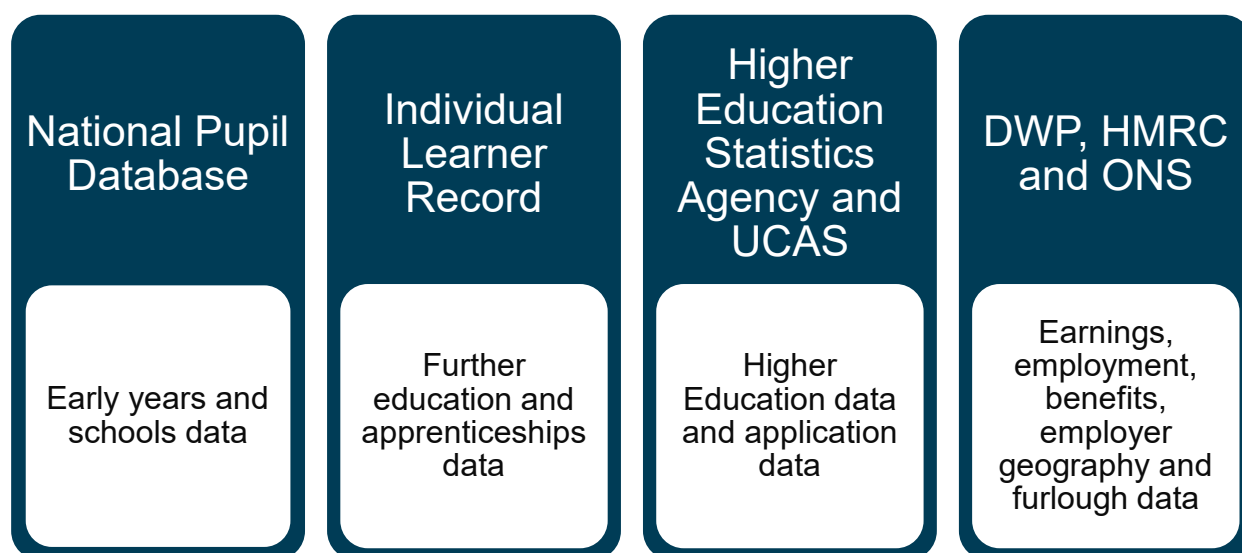
available for approved third party researchers to access and analyse on the Office for National Statistics' (ONS) Secure Research Service (SRS) platform.

The LEO outcomes data has undergone a thorough cleaning process in preparation for robust secondary analysis alongside the education information that DfE also holds. The capacity to analyse these longer-term labour market outcomes together, at person level, enables developments in the assessment of education policy and provision with greater accuracy than ever before.

This is a unique source of information, with the potential to provide transformative insight and evidence on the long-term employment outcomes and educational pathways of millions of individuals.

The LEO data is available through the ONS SRS and is referred to as the LEO Standard Extract (LEO SE).

Diagram 1: Data coverage of the LEO Dataset



The coverage of data available in LEO is:

- All people born since 1985 who have engaged with the state school education system in England, and those attending independent schools who are included in the Key Stage KS4 or KS5 data. Scottish/Welsh learners will appear in this data if they have attended an English setting at some point.
- People who are older than this and have attended an English Further Education (FE) institution since 2002/03 (individuals located within the Longitudinal Individualised Learner Record (ILR) data).

HESA – Higher Education Statistics Authority

- For English Higher Education Institutions (HEIs), all records are included. This will include international students and Scottish/Welsh learners who have not previously attended an English educational setting.
- For Scottish and Welsh HEIs, only individuals that are identified as previously attending an English educational setting are included. These are defined as anyone who can be linked to any of the other requested NPD datasets or in the ILR through their 'PupilMatchingReference' (PMR).

Data Source and Year Available

Table 1: Data Source and Earliest Academic Tax Year Available

Data Source	Earliest Academic / Tax Year Available
Education	
NPD – National Pupil Database	2001/02
HESA – Higher Education Statistics Authority	2004/05
UCAS – Universities and Colleges Admissions Service	2006/07
LILR – Longitudinal Individualised Learner Record	2002/03
Earnings, Benefits and Tax	
P45	1997/98
P14 & IDBR – Inter-Departmental Business Register	2003/04
SA – Self-Assessment	2013/14
Benefits – National Benefits Database, Jobseeker's Allowance, Personal Independence Payment, Universal Credit (NBD, JSA, PIP and UC)	1999/00
Geography	2004/05
CJRS – Coronavirus Job Retention Scheme	2020/21
SEISS – Self-Employment Income Support Scheme	2020/21

Overview of Cohorts in LEO

Table 2: Overview of Cohort in the LEO Data

	EYFSP	Key stage 1		Key stage 2				Key stage 3			Key stage 4		Key stage 5		
Birth Cohort	Yr0/R	Yr1	Y2	Yr3	Yr4	Yr5	Yr6	Yr7	Yr8	Yr9	Yr10	Yr11	Yr12	Yr13	Age in most recent year or LEO data
1985/86							1996/97					2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	34
1986/87							1997/98				2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	33
1987/88							1998/99			2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	32
1988/89							1999/20		2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	31
1989/90							2000/01	2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	30
1990/91							2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	2008/09	29
1991/92			1997/98			2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	2008/09	2009/10	28
1992/93			1998/99		2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	2008/09	2009/10	2010/11	27
1993/94			1999/00	2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	2008/09	2009/10	2010/11	2011/12	26
1994/95			2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	2008/09	2009/10	2010/11	2011/12	2012/13	25
1995/96		2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	2008/09	2009/10	2010/11	2011/12	2012/13	2013/14	24
1996/97	2001/02	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	2008/09	2009/10	2010/11	2011/12	2012/13	2013/14	2014/15	23
1997/98	2002/03	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	2008/09	2009/10	2010/11	2011/12	2012/13	2013/14	2014/15	2015/16	22
1998/99	2003/04	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	2008/09	2009/10	2010/11	2011/12	2012/13	2013/14	2014/15	2015/16	2016/17	21
1999/00	2004/05	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	2008/09	2009/10	2010/11	2011/12	2012/13	2013/14	2014/15	2015/16	2016/17	2017/18	20
2000/01	2005/06	2006/07	2007/08	2008/09	2009/10	2010/11	2011/12	2012/13	2013/14	2014/15	2015/16	2016/17	2017/18	2018/19	19

NB: The age listed in the table above is the oldest age for which DWP and HMRC data is available for individuals born in these cohorts in LEO.

Section 3: Project Application Guidance

As mentioned in Section 1: there is guidance on how to complete a project application on PASS. However, the following guidance is LEO application specific

where each header aligns to the titled section of the PASS application form. Following this guidance will ensure all relevant information is included in your application for LEO and will help with the time taken for your application to be reviewed.

Dataset Basket

- LEO can only be accessed in the SRS without any other SRS data catalogue data. Ensure **no other SRS data** are in the application's Data Basket upon submission. Refer to [External Data](#) for more information on accessing non-SRS catalogue data with LEO.

Purpose

- LEO hosts data **for individuals in England**. Please ensure your research questions, methods, and outputs reflect this.
- Be careful to **avoid references to the UK** or other nations unless they are clearly caveated.
- Ensure to detail all known **limitations** to the project.

Methodology

- **Consider a wide range of methodological approaches** to investigating research and evaluation questions.
- **Include a rationale** for all chosen variables, including details of how these will be used.
- Statistical analysis - Detail the model's assumptions, explain how these assumptions will be tested, outlining any limitations or caveats.
- Economic analysis - Indicate whether a comparison group will be used, detail the approach for isolating confounding factors, explain how missing data will be identified and managed, and specify the tests that will be applied to compare outcomes.
- Where the research question involves measuring impact, which implies causality, **explain how confounding variables will be addressed** to ensure valid conclusions.
- **Include as much detail as possible** to enable understanding of the proposed methods.

Datasets (Supporting Documents)

Please ensure the following are adhered to:

- Attach a **completed Variable Request Form (VRF)**, as mentioned in Section 1, as this is essential for mapping your data request in the SRS.
- Use the **latest version** of the VRF provided and ensure the formatting is not altered.
- Ensure all columns are **unhidden** in your VRF, as hidden data may delay your application.
- Indicate which **‘Data Tables’** are required by completing **column F** in the VRF sheet.
- **Justify each data table** selected in column H of the ‘Data Tables’ sheet, to ensure your request is clear and well-supported, detailing why the table/variables are required to meet the research aims. Requests without clear justification will be queried to ask for more detail, which will extend the application process. If the justification for the table isn’t sufficient, it could lead to the table request being rejected.
- For each of the ‘Data Tables’ selected, ensure the **corresponding data sheet is complete**.
- Only select the **variables needed** for your project and ensure that requests **do not include all available variables in LEO**, as these will not be approved.
- On each selected data table, please:
 - clearly specify on the corresponding sheet which **variables are required**,
 - put “Yes” and “No” to specify if the variable is required in the column labelled ‘Data request data item required?’ do not leave the variable blank,
 - check the “column on years” to see if the year you require is available,
 - indicate in the column labelled ‘Data request years required?’ which years are required and do not leave this blank on any required variable.
- If you are requesting **Children in Need (CIN) or Children Looked After (CLA) data**, please ensure that Output Area (OA) variables are not included, as these cannot be used together.

External Data

Please consider the type of external data you’re requesting and if it would be permitted alongside the LEO data you require:

- **Tier 1 – Likely allowed:** Public, unmodified data (e.g. geography lookups, IMD, published stats, syntax).
- **Tier 2 – May be allowed:** Public but modified data (e.g. aggregated stats, de-identified IDs).
- **Tier 3 – Not allowed:** Non-public or identifiable data (e.g. names, detailed addresses, operational IDs).

Please consider everything you may require to fulfil the aims of this project. Anything extra required at a later date that is not specified explicitly in the initial application will have to go through the project change process. This includes the application being checked again by the SRS teams, Data Owners (where applicable) and the Research Accreditation Panel which adds time to receiving your data request(s).

LEO Pseudonymisation service

- The LEO pseudonymisation service has been introduced to ensure that body corporate identities are protected in accordance with the legal gateway requirements.
- The pseudonymisation service will be offered to researchers who wish to use **external organisational level data** alongside LEO within the ONS Secure Research Service (SRS). The ONS SRS teams provide an ongoing service which will pseudonymise a set of body corporate identifiers contained in external datasets researchers wish to ingest alongside their LEO project. This service will allow researchers to join approved external data to LEO data and undertake analysis at organisational level.
- For **more details on the service**, please see contact SRS.Project.Feasibility@ons.gov.uk who will be able to send across more information including a guidance document.

Concluding Guidance for LEO Applications

We hope this guidance provides clarity and support for researchers applying to access the Longitudinal Education Outcomes dataset via the Secure Research Service. By following the steps outlined and ensuring applications are complete and accurate, you can help streamline the approval process and make the most of this valuable resource. For further assistance, please refer to the additional resources mentioned in this document or contact the SRS Customer Support team at srs.customer.support@ons.gov.uk.

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